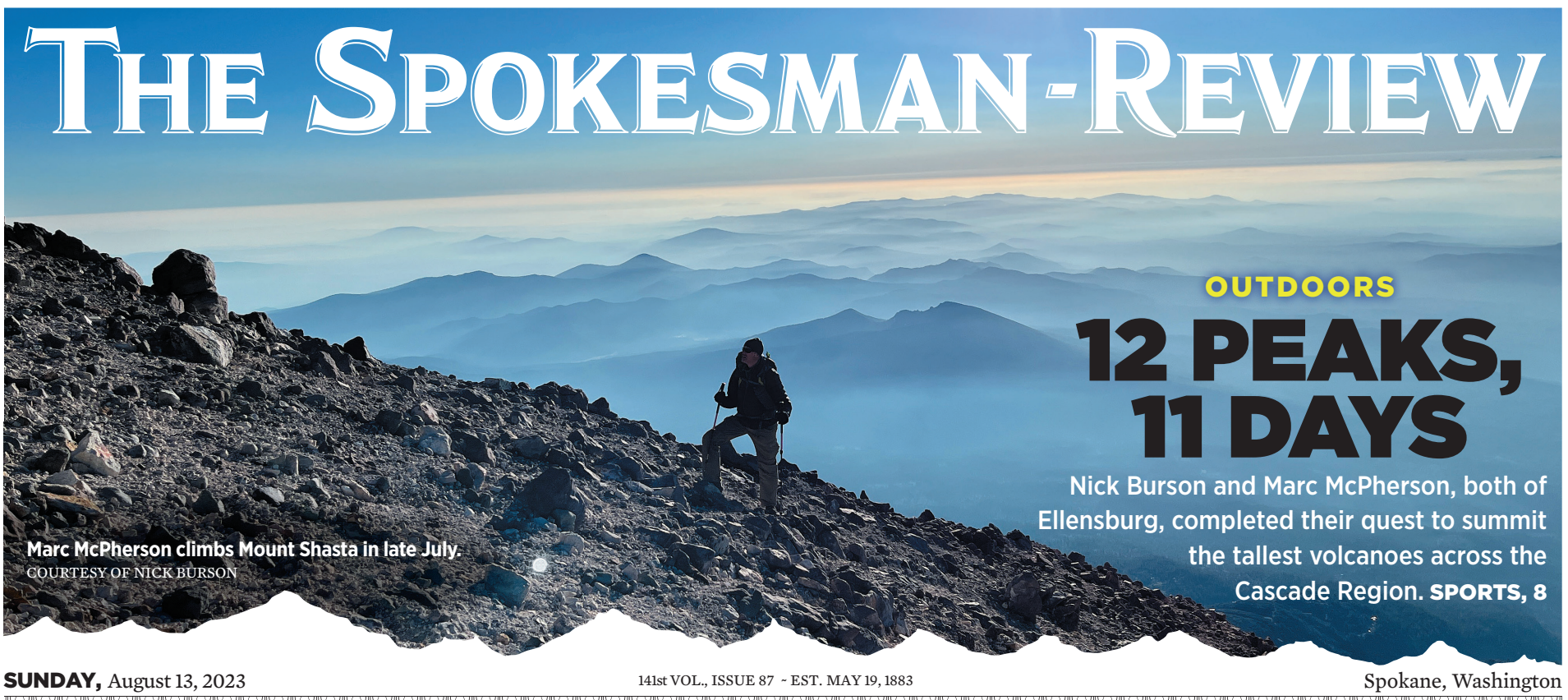
THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

SUNDAY, August 13, 2023 | 141st VOL., ISSUE 87 ~ EST. MAY 19, 1883 | Spokane, Washington



Marc McPherson climbs Mount Shasta in late July.
COURTESY OF NICK BURSON

OUTDOORS

12 PEAKS, 11 DAYS

Nick Burson and Marc McPherson, both of Ellensburg, completed their quest to summit the tallest volcanoes across the Cascade Region. **SPORTS, 8**

WATER WITH LIME





JESSE TINSLEY/THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

A dozen or so Lime scooters lie on the Spokane River bottom last August at the east end of snxw menəʔ (sin-HOO-men-huh) Island in Riverfront Park.

Tossing scooters in the river might be fun, but it's hazardous to the ecosystem

By Colin Tiernan
THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

The scooters lie at the bottom of the Spokane River, blurry blobs of green and white under the shimmering water.

Sometimes vandals chuck them in, forming clusters beneath the walking bridges in Riverfront Park. They show up here and there downriver, too, perhaps carried by strong currents in spring. A few dead Lime scooters rest in the sediment of Latah Creek, which empties into the Spokane River a mile or so west of downtown.

River experts say people have thrown hundreds of the battery-powered scooters into Spokane's waters. And they all agree that's a problem.

"Sooner or later, those batteries will do bad things," said Tim Sharp, a magnet fisherman who hauls scooters and other debris out of the Spokane River as a hobby. "My biggest thing is I don't want to see the scooters harm the fish."

See **LIME, 9**

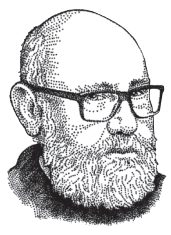
MORE ON SCOOTERS

AGENCIES UNSURE OF HOW SAFE THE VEHICLES ARE

Lime claims that a small percentage of trips result in an incident, but local data is difficult to find, if it exists at all.
NEWS, 9

Developer Stone's role in homelessness efforts stirs debate

Videos, donations, committee roles questioned after purchase of Trent shelter



SHAWN VESTAL
SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

Four years ago, developer Larry Stone offered his cure for Spokane's homelessness – and drove a wedge into the political debate about the issue.

In his video "Curing Spokane," the developer and big-time spender on conservative campaigns unfolded scene after scene of aggressive, frightening homeless people, linked them explicitly to crime and proposed building a big new jail to put them in.

It infuriated homeless advocates and those calling for a housing-based solution to the crisis, while delighting those supporting police sweeps and a heavy reliance on incarceration.

The video became one of many bright lines between then-mayoral candidate Nadine Woodward, who was running on jail-or-shelter ultimatums for homeless people, and then-Council President Ben Stuckart, who argued for treating homelessness as primarily a housing issue. Woodward praised Stone's video and thanked him for "calling for a stronger, more visible police presence" downtown, and Stuckart criticized it as "embarrassing, inciting and shaming our people to make a political point."

See **VESTAL, 8**



TYLER TJOMSLAND/THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

Former Spokane Tribe chairwoman Carol Evans, right, and her husband, Terry Evans, left, wrestle a chinook salmon into the Little Spokane River during a release by the Inland Northwest Land Conservancy and the Spokane Tribe on Friday at the Glen Tana Conservation Area in Spokane.

'WHAT THE ANCESTORS WOULD HAVE SEEN'

Salmon release in Little Spokane River cultural experience, symbol for future

By Michael Wright
THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

The salmon wiggled in the tanks on the back of the truck, throwing water into the sky. A few people standing on the truck bed next to the tanks netted the fish, one at a time, then wrestled them into a rubber tube and passed it down a line of people, all smiles and laughter.

At the end of the line, the chinook salmon were released from the tube into the Little Spokane River. Once in the water, the salmon darted away, their shadows showing on the river bottom as they hustled for cover.

Spokane Tribal Historian Warren Seyler watched from the bank. He thought back to what the river would have looked like long ago, before dams blocked the chinook salmon runs that his ancestors relied on. He said people don't realize just how many salmon there were.

"Take that shadow that just went by," Seyler said as one of the salmon headed off, "and multiply it by 20,000. That's what the

See **SALMON, 8**

AMMON BUNDY ARRESTED

Far-right political activist was detained Friday night in Gem County for an outstanding warrant. Bond was set at $10,000.
NEWS, 11

ICONIC EATERIES: MAXWELL HOUSE

Newest owners wanted to hold onto "old-school feeling" that kept regulars coming back at the West Central establishment. **NW, 1**

NEW LOCATION, SAME INNOVATIONS

Engineers from a storied Seattle firm have relocated to Spokane and continue to unearth discoveries. **BUSINESS, 1**



PHOTO COURTESY OF WILLIAMSON & ASSOCIATES

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FROM THE FRONT PAGE

How safe are Lime scooters? Gov't agencies say they have no idea

Company claims small fraction of trips result in reported incident

By Colin Tiernan
THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

The Spokane City Council has written two sets of safety laws for electric scooter riders.

Anyone riding a personal electric scooter has to wear a helmet. Anyone riding a Lime scooter does not.

It's a distinction that many observers have called hypocritical, but City Council members have defended it and pointed out that Lime prevents its customers from recklessly speeding.

Lime throttles its scooters with automatic speed limits that users can't override, unless they're going downhill. The company caps its scooters at 7.5 mph when they're in Kendall Yards, Riverfront Park, portions of the Centennial Trail and on Gonzaga University's campus. Riders can't exceed 15 mph in the rest of the city.

It's unclear if Lime scooter riders in Spokane suffer head injuries at disproportionate rates. Local data on Lime scooter safety is difficult to find, if it exists at all.

Spokane Police Department spokeswoman Julie Humphreys said law enforcement received 111 Lime-related calls for service between May and late July.

But Humphreys said the police department's staff doesn't have time to sift through the data to try to find whether any of those calls were connected to an injury. She also said she didn't know how often Spokane police officers have issued citations to people riding personal scooters without a helmet. The Spokesman-Review in 2019 reported that the police department issued 36 citations in 2018 to people who flouted the city's helmet law.

The Spokane Fire Department said it doesn't track scooter injuries or collisions. Providence Sacred Heart Medical Center, the region's largest hospital system, said it could probably figure out how many people have required medical attention for Lime-related injuries, but couldn't provide data in time for this story.

The Washington State Department of Transportation said it doesn't track scooter collision or injury data, and deferred to the Washington State Patrol. The Washington State Patrol said it doesn't track that data either, and deferred to the Washington Traffic Safety Commission.

Washington Traffic Safety Commission Communications Manager Erica Stineman did not respond to multiple requests for comment.

Russell Murphy, Lime's global communications director, said only 0.02% of scooter trips result in a reported incident, and only a fraction of those end in serious injury.

Colin Tiernan can be reached at (509) 459-5039 or at colint@spokesman.com.

LIME

Continued from 1

Lime scooters first appeared in Spokane five years ago when the company launched a small pilot program. The city signed a contract with Lime shortly thereafter, and today Spokane is home to about 1,500 scooters from March to November every year.

Spokane has granted Lime a monopoly and doesn't allow any competitors to operate in the city. The Spokane City Council will reassess Lime's contract in the coming months before it expires at the end of November.

Electric scooters aren't new, but in the past few years well-funded startups such as Lime have made them common sights in cities around the world.

Lime markets its scooters and bikes as a convenient, cheap and environmentally friendly form of transportation. They're easy to find throughout Spokane and nearly anyone can rent one so long as they have the Lime app on their smartphone. Lime says millions of people use its vehicles every year.

The e-scooter boom hasn't been without downsides, however. Cities have been caught flatfooted as thousands of electric scooters have appeared, almost overnight, on their streets.

Scooters scattered haphazardly on sidewalks can create obstacles for people in wheelchairs and the blind. Pedestrians often say it's frightening or unsafe when scooter riders whiz by them. Environmentalists argue scooters have become a pollutant in waterways.

Wherever electric scooters show up, people throw them in rivers, lakes and oceans. No one seems to have a strong theory for why.

"That's the million-dollar question," said Paul Swanson, one of Sharp's fellow magnet fishermen. "I have no clue. Bad parenting?"

Eugene Mabie, who magnet fishes with Sharp and Swanson, said staff in Spokane's parks department have told him many of the Lime vandals heave them into the river while drunk or high.

Lime scooters pose a serious threat to aquatic life according to Hugh Lefcort, a Gonzaga University biology professor who specializes in ecotoxicology.

Unlike iron, lithium and heavy metals in rechargeable batteries are toxic, Lefcort said. High doses of lithium can impact heart contraction in mammals. The cobalt and nickel in batteries can cause damage, too.

"All heavy metals are toxic to different degrees," Lefcort said. "Some of them affect kidneys, some of them have neurological effects. They definitely affect egg development of salmon and aquatic insects."

Russell Murphy, Lime's communications director, said the company uses the best available waterproofing technology to encase its batteries.

"Water ingress is not a strong concern," Murphy said. "I don't want to say we're 100% confident that nothing is able to leak out, but we waterproof our batteries to the strongest extent possible."

Many Lime scooters have sat in the Spokane River for years, however.

Since 2019, Swanson, Sharp and Mabie's magnet fishing club has pulled out 257 Lime scooters. The fishermen give the scooters back to Lime, and while they don't do it for the money, Lime has intermittently paid them for the work. Sharp said the company has given the club about $800.

The problem, magnet fishermen said, is that many more scooters remain hidden underwater. It's impossible to pull out an invisible scooter, they said, because they aren't especially magnetic.

Magnet fishermen generally focus on pulling out metal objects. They cast strong magnets, on the ends of strong ropes, into the water. Then they drag in what they catch. Spokane magnet fishermen have found all sorts of rusty treasure, including bathtubs, iron park benches and bulky pieces of railroad equipment.

Lime scooters are primarily plastic, though, and can only be snagged with grappling hooks. If the fishermen can't see the scooter, they can't hook it.

"There must be enormous numbers of Lime scooters in our river that we can't see, that are buried by sediment or too deep," said Jule Schultz, the Spokane Riverkeeper's cleanup director.

Schultz and Sharp said only Lime knows how many scooters lie on the river bottom.

"They have GPS trackers, so they know when they hit the water," Sharp said.

But Lime won't say how many scooters are in the river.

"It's not something we usually share," Murphy said.

Murphy said Lime continually works to retrieve its scooters, even when they're broken. He also noted that the newest generation of Lime scooters, launched this year, weigh in at 60 pounds. That makes them significantly heavier than the previous models and far more difficult to heave over a railing.

Magnet fishermen and representatives from the Spokane Riverkeeper mostly said they don't want to vilify Lime. They say the problem is caused by vandals illegally throwing its property off bridges.

But they all said Lime and government agencies need to do a far better job protecting the river. The scooter pollution issue has been overlooked for years, they said.

"At what point should the industry be mandated to insulate our waterways from the impact – the potential negative impact – of these scooters?" Spokane Riverkeeper Executive Director Jerry White asked. "It shouldn't be ignored and swept under the rug."

Bursting into the limelight

Brad Bao and Toby Sun founded Lime six years ago and headquartered their new business in San Francisco.

Both came from venture capital backgrounds and appear to have a knack for fundraising. Lime has received hundreds of millions of dollars from massive investment firms and tech giants, including Uber and Alphabet, Google's parent company.

All that money has fueled Lime's explosive growth as it tries to take over the market. Lime scooters didn't exist in early 2017; now they're on street corners in 250 cities on five continents.

Lime isn't publicly traded, so it's difficult to pinpoint how much it's worth, but analysts at different times have valued the company between $500 million and $2 billion.

In February, Lime said it was the first micromobility company to post a fully profitable year. It brought in $466 million from 120 million trips and, when accounting for interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization, earned $15 million.

Despite those big numbers, Lime scooters are cheap for individual riders. In Spokane, it costs $1 to activate a scooter and 39 cents a minute to ride it. A 5-minute trip costs $2.95.

Lime has been a financial boon for Spokane City Hall. The company pays the city 75 cents per vehicle for every day a vehicle is out on the streets, plus a $17,000 annual fee. Spokane has received $530,000 from Lime since 2019, including $190,000 last year.

While Lime and its competitors bring cities extra revenue, electric scooters have caused local governments plenty of headaches.

In addition to pollution concerns, some city politicians have called scooters a nuisance and safety issue. Multiple cities have prohibited them.

This April, 89% of Parisians voted in favor of an electric scooter ban. France's national academy of medicine has called them a public health threat because dozens of riders have died and many more have been injured.

It's difficult, if not impossible, to find injury data on electric scooters in Spokane. No government agency or hospital at the state or local level was able to provide any scooter collision or injury statistics for this story.

Who's in charge?

White and Schultz, who work for the nonprofit dedicated to cleaning up the Spokane River, said they've tried to figure out which government agency is responsible for protecting the river from trash.

"When it comes to responsibility or funding, we couldn't get to the bottom of it," Schultz said.

According to Washington law, environmental protection of state rivers is the Department of Natural Resources' job.

But Joe Smillie, the department's communications director for aquatic lands, told The Spokesman-Review to talk to local law enforcement when asked for comment on Lime scooters in the Spokane River.

"I asked around and nobody here seems to have heard anything about the problem," Smillie said in an email. He did not respond to multiple follow-up requests for comment.

Throwing a Lime scooter in the river is illegal, per Spokane law, but it's unclear if the Spokane Police Department has cited anyone for doing it. Police spokeswoman Julie Humphreys said public records staff didn't have time to sift through the data to answer that question.

Going after Lime scooter vandals would be difficult, Humphreys said.

"No one's throwing things in the river in broad daylight in front of officers," she said. "There's no evidence, there's no witnesses."

Murphy, Lime's spokesman, said the company works with Spokane's code enforcement department instead of the police.

When the city in late July learned that The Spokesman-Review was writing about scooters in the river, the code enforcement department alerted Lime. City planner Colin Quinn-Hurst said in an email that Lime, in response, planned to remove several scooters from under the Howard Street walking bridge.

Mabie said Lime last week met with Spokane's magnet fishermen, who have recently pulled out four more scooters in Riverfront Park – numbers 254 through 257 on the club's all-time tally.

City spokesman Brian Walker said Lime hopes to work more closely with local magnet fishermen in the future. Sharp said Lime has proposed paying the magnet fishing club an annual lump sum for scooter retrieval.

"They're putting a Band-Aid on it," he said. "They want to throw us $3,000 a year or something. To me, that really sounds ridiculous for the amount of work we put in this. A true recovery business, they would charge that in an afternoon, maybe."

Murphy declined to say how much each scooter costs, but it's likely Spokane magnet fishermen have saved Lime thousands of dollars by returning 257 scooters.

It's unclear what legal obligation Lime has to retrieve its property, but the Washington State Department of Ecology is charged by state law to clean up chemical spills in waterways. That means if an oil tank truck or Tesla crashed into the Spokane River, Ecology would lead the effort to get it out.

The Department of Ecology said it was unaware Lime scooters are in the river.

"We haven't been called on one yet, very surprisingly, and I've been at this for several years – since Lime has been in Spokane," said Sean Thompson, a hazardous materials specialist for the Department of Ecology.

Thompson said if someone told Ecology about a scooter in the river, the agency would try to remove it.

Failed experiment?

Spokane residents have a history of destroying new and convenient forms of transportation.

Paul Lindholdt, an Eastern Washington University philosophy and English professor who edited and co-wrote "The Spokane River," said the Lime situation reminds him of the city's short-lived lilac bike experiment in the late 1990s.

"At that time the city was freely providing bicycles," Lindholdt wrote in an email. "They were painted purple to match the theme of the Lilac City."

The 50 bikes didn't last long.

"The infamous lilac bikes of Spokane were, infamously, thrown into the Spokane River in 1997," The Spokesman-Review wrote in 2018, shortly before Lime's local debut. "Fingers crossed the electric Lime bikes and scooters that will appear in Spokane this summer don't face the same watery fate."

Schultz said people have been mistreating the Spokane River for more than a century.

"Our river used to be the town dump," he said.

The Spokane River contains enormous quantities of trash. In 2015, divers spent a week pulling out garbage between Division Street and Hamilton Street. They loaded up two barges worth of trash every day.

This year alone, the Spokane Riverkeeper has removed 23,000 pounds of trash. Schultz estimated 1,000 pounds of that was Lime scooters.

"Seeing trash in the river, it really touches my very core," he said. "There's something inside me that gets, maybe, irrationally angry."

Sharp said he's tired of pulling out Lime scooters over and over. It's different from magnet fishing, where there's excitement with every cast into the water and a constant possibility of discovery.

"That's all we've been doing is Lime scooters," Sharp said. "In a way it kind of took the fun out of it last year because we kind of stopped doing all the magnet fishing."

If people can't be mature enough to stop throwing Lime scooters in the river, maybe Spokane can't handle the responsibility of having them, White said.

"If you can't keep them out of the river and out of surface waters everywhere across the Earth, sorry," he said, "failed experiment, and that's that."

Colin Tiernan can be reached at (509) 459-5039 or at colint@spokesman.com.

VESTAL

Continued from 8

have said they felt they had no choice but to approve a deal that had been orchestrated in the dark. Winter was approaching, Camp Hope was growing and there was no alternative in sight.

Kinnear said the council felt, "We're stuck. There is no other option. There is no Plan B."

Range Media recently reported that Sanders had been part of a tour of the property in March 2022 with the mayor, council members and a representative of Stone's company. At that time, Stone had not yet bought the building – he did so shortly thereafter.

In a $500 donation to the Woodward campaign made six months later, Sanders listed her employer as LB Stone Properties, and her occupation as a manager.

Sanders' involvement with Stone came as a surprise to some, as did comments late last week by Katy Bruya – a senior vice president at Washington Trust and co-chair of Hello for Good – at a meeting of the Spokane Homeless Coalition.

Bruya was asked about Stone's involvement with Hello for Good, and she replied that he had not been active in the group, attending only three or four meetings himself.

"He ultimately sent Theresa Sanders," she said. "He said, 'Can I just send Theresa in my stead?' "

Smith responded in shock, and shot out an email to community partners, saying he could not support a regional authority built on the foundation of "Curing Spokane" and tainted by a conflict of interest that "borders on open disdain for the very people it should be intended to serve."

Stuckart said the relationship had not been disclosed, and that, "You can't say she's representing him over here, but not representing him over there."

Many of Stone's critics see the shelter as a kind of Potemkin Village – created to present the illusion of sufficient shelter beds, in order to justify the enforcement of the sit-lie and anti-camping laws and the jail-first ideas built into Stone's video. Under the prevailing law set by a federal court in a case known as Martin v. Boise, cities may not cite or arrest homeless people if there isn't sufficient shelter space.

To them, the ties between Sanders and Stone only fueled these suspicions. And given Stone's beliefs, they wonder about the impetus behind incarceration-oriented language in the proposal by Spokane Unite, including a guiding principle that says, "Detention remains a necessary accountability tool."

The final push

Representatives of Spokane Unite and Hello for Good insist that the concerns are unfounded. Sanders said she has attended only three or four Hello for Good meetings, and never on Stone's behalf.

"I've only ever represented my own views," she said in a text message. "If Larry felt informed knowing I was there, that's up to him."

She also said, "I don't work for Larry."

In an email, Bruya said her comment was being taken "wildly out of context," and that Stone had merely suggested she meet with Sanders.

Cooley said Stone has not been involved with the Spokane Unite effort, and that the political disputes over the proposal – from both sides of the spectrum – have become deeply discouraging.

He said that he sees the most important element of a regional approach is the creation of the governance structure. He wishes they had avoided trying to identify principles and philosophical goals, and proposed a completely "agnostic" approach based only on governance, leaving philosophy to those who would eventually run the organization.

Several people said the detention language in the Spokane Unite proposal is not something only Stone might favor – in a communitywide conversation, with a proposal that needs to win the favor of the left-leaning City Council and conservative-leaning County Commission, the idea of incarceration as one part of the picture is by no means an outlier.

It's basically the Woodward philosophy, and she won the last election, they note.

Trying to thread the political needle on homelessness is a big lift. From the start, the push to emulate the Houston way has been almost universally supported in the abstract, even as people have tended to qualify their support – "the devil is in the details," more than one official has said.

Stone and his involvement – or at least suspicions about it – is not the only devilish detail, but for those who reject his cure, it's become one of the biggest.

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The Spokane City Council changed its contract with Lime after this story, requiring the company to keep its scooters out of the river.

THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW
Washington Idaho

NEWS > LOCAL GOVERNMENT

Lime soon to return to Spokane streets after contract renewed

June 3, 2024 | Updated Mon., June 3, 2024 at 9:29 p.m.



Jacob Proost and Ben Stone ride Lime scooters in spring 2019 in Riverfront Park. (Dan Pelle/THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW) Buy this photo

By Emry Dinman
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Lime scooters will return to Spokane streets in the coming days following a noted absence this spring, after the Spokane City Council voted Monday to renew a stricter contract with the micro mobility giant Neutron Holdings.

The contract, which will be in effect until December 2026 unless terminated early due to contract violations, was approved 5-2 Monday, with Councilman Michael Cathcart and Councilwoman Lili Navarrete voting against.

City officials hope the new contract will mitigate some of the harms associated with them, including users leaving them and clogging city streets and waterways or driving them on downtown sidewalks.

The electric scooters, which typically show up every March and continue scooting until November, have been absent from Spokane's streets in recent months. The Spokane City Council, hoping to modify the terms of its contract with any scooter vendor operating in the city, opted last year not to grant Lime a two-year extension while new proposals were explored.

Only adults 18 or older can legally ride the scooters.

The new contract will include new concessions from Lime to prevent some of the chronic problems associated with their devices. These include requirements that its electric scooters have technology to detect when they're being illegally driven on the sidewalk, that some of the devices be located in impoverished – and thus less profitable – areas of the city, and, for the first time, that make it Lime's responsibility to remove scooters dumped in the Spokane River.

Lime will have 24 hours to remove any scooter thrown into any body of water in the city, so long as it is "practically possible and safe to do so." That clock begins ticking immediately after a submerged scooter is reported by the public or, more likely, the company's own software.

If the company fails to do so within the allotted time, the city can retrieve the scooters at Lime's expense and plans to contract with Spokane-based Able Clean-Up Technologies to do so. Lime will not be allowed to unilaterally retrieve scooters around the river's hydroelectric dams, a task which requires a specialized contractor.

Hundreds of the scooters, powered by batteries with toxic heavy metals that risk leaching despite waterproofing, have been pulled out of the river and intersecting waterways since

Lime first hit Spokane streets in 2018.

THE SPOKESMAN-REVIEW

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Jesse Tinsley

Meet Jesse Tinsley. As a certified drone pilot, this veteran Spokesman-Review photographer often can be seen capturing beautiful aerial photographs of our region. Sometimes though, the job requires getting down with the dogs.